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Psalms

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Psalms

A. Overview and Summary.

1. Psalms is the longest book in the bible, consisting of 150 songs, hymns and prayers written over 1,000 years of Israel's history. There are several different authors, such as King David, who wrote seventy-three of the Psalms. There are poems of Asaph, the Sons of Korah and others, including even Moses and Solomon. But a large number, 49 are anonymous. The oldest Psalm is that attributed to Moses (Psalm 90). The latest is most likely number 137, written when the Hebrews were held captive by the Babylonians from 536 to 538 BC. We will spend some more discussion on that particular Psalm later in this lesson.
2. The subject matter is diverse, covering a variety of topics such as worship, thanksgiving, God, creation, war, sin and evil, wisdom, judgement, justice and the Messiah to come. The book of Psalms is a collection that was used in temple worship that that focused on praise and worship to God. The early Christian church also used the Psalms for daily prayer and worship. We have evidence of this in our New Testament where the believers would gather in homes.
"Be filled with the Spirit. Speak to one another with psalms, hymns and spiritual songs." (Ephesians 5:18b-19a)
"Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly as you teach and admonish one another with all wisdom, and as you sing psalms, hymns and spiritual songs with gratitude in your hearts to God." (Colossians 3:16)
"Is any one of you in trouble? He should pray. Is anyone happy? Let him sing songs of praise." (James 5:13)
3. Since the book of Psalms is the longest book in our Bibles, we will only give a brief summary of some of the key passages from some of the Psalms.

B. Psalm 2 speaks of the coming Kingdom of Christ: "The LORD said to me, "You are my Son; today I have begotten you. Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage, and the ends of the earth your possession" (Vs.2:7b-8).

C. Psalm 3 was written by David when he fled from his son Absalom: "But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the liger of my head" (Vs. 3:3).

D. Psalm 8 is one of praise to God by David: "O LORD, our Lord, how majestic is your name in all the earth! You have set your glory above the heavens" (Vs. 8:1).

E. Psalm 9 recounts God's wonderful deeds by David: "I will give thanks to the LORD with my whole heart; I will recount all of your wonderful deeds. I will be glad and exult in you; I will sing praise to your name, O Most High" (Vs. 9:1-2).

F. Psalm 14 is a lamentation by David over the failure of man to recognize God and their corruption: "The fool says in his heart, 'There is no God.' They are corrupt, they do abominable deeds; there is none who does good" (Vs. 14:1).

G. Psalm 19 is one of praise by David: "The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork (Vs. 19:1). "The law of the LORD is perfect, reviving the soul; the testimony of the LORD is sure, making wise the simple" (Vs. 19:7).

H. Psalm 22 was a cry of David in distress but contains prophetic words pertaining to the crucifixion of Christ: "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Vs. 22:1a). "I am poured out like water, and all my bones are out of joint; my heart is like wax; it is melted within my breast" (Vs. 22:14). "They divide my garments among them, and for my clothing they cast lots" (Vs. 22:18).

I. Psalm 23 is the familiar assurance that God is our Shepherd written by David the shepherd: "Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me; your rod and your staff, they comfort me" (Vs. 23:4).

J. Psalm 51 was written by David after his sin of adultery and murder was exposed by Nathan the prophet: "Have mercy on me, O God, according to your steadfast love; according to your abundant mercy blot out my transgressions. Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity, and cleanse me from my sin!" (Vs. 51:1-2).

K. Psalm 82 is a very insightful glimpse into God's organization of angelic beings and His rebuke of them: "God has taken his place in the divine council; in the midst of the gods he holds judgment: 'How long will you judge unjustly and show partiality to the wicked?'" (Vs. 82:1-2). "You are gods, sons of the Most High, all of you; nevertheless, like men you shall die, and fall like any prince'" (Vs. 82:6-7).

L. Psalm 90 is the one psalm attributed to Moses: "Lord, you have been our dwelling place in all generations. Before the mountains were brought forth, or ever you had formed the earth and the world, from everlasting to everlasting you are God" (Vs. 90:1-2).

M. Psalm 119 is the longest psalm with 176 verses. Here is just one verse that has been encouragement to many in their daily walk: “Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path” (Vs. 119:105).

N. Psalm 136 tells of God’s steadfast love: “Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever” (Vs. 136:1).

O. Psalm 137 is what is called an imprecatory psalm in that it speaks of violence against the enemies of the Israelites.

1. Many have walked away from the Christian faith due to not understanding this psalm within the context in which it was written. Jerusalem had fallen to the Babylonians, who took them captive to Babylon, and to the Edomites who looted the city. Destruction of the city and abuse of the captives was violent. Imprecate means “to pray against”. The captives were told to “sing us a song of Zion” (Vs.137:1) which added further humiliation to them.
2. The psalm ends with the cry for revenge: “O daughter of Babylon, doomed to be destroyed, blessed shall he be who repays you with what you have done to us! Blessed shall he be who takes your little ones and dashes them against the rock!” (Vs. 137:8-9). This psalm was written during a period of harsh emotion brought on by God’s judgement of the Israelites due to their idolatry and sin. But critics point to this passage, which comes after psalm 136 affirming God’s love, as something that does not fit in what they think divinely inspired Scripture should be.
3. We have to interpret this psalm within its historical context as well as the entire counsel of Scripture. Romans 12:17-19 says: “Do not repay anyone evil for evil. Be careful to do what is right in the eyes of everyone. If it is possible, as far as it depends on you, live at peace with everyone. Do not take revenge, my dear friends, but leave room for God’s wrath, for it is written: ‘It is mine to avenge; I will repay,’ says the Lord”.

P. Psalm 150 ends the book of psalms with praise: “Praise the LORD! Praise God in his sanctuary; praise him in his mighty heavens! Praise him for his mighty deeds; praise him according to his excellent greatness!” (Vs. 150:1-2).

Q. Discussion Questions, Application and Passing it on.

1. The Psalms are reflective of Israel over many years of its history and interaction with God. Do you see how they could be incorporated into your personal or

corporate time of worship?

2. Psalm 22 contains prophecy about Christ's crucifixion. Consider using this one in your personal witnessing to an unbeliever.
3. Are you able to respond to an atheist or critic of the Bible about what they may bring up regarding Psalm 137?

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)